coursera | MoMA

Seeing Through Photographs

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Part I: Introduction
- Introduction to Module 1 — Reading • 2 min
- Artistic Equivalents — Reading • 2 min
- Vik Muniz on Photographing the Familiar — Video • 3 min

Part II: Telescopes and Cameras
- Introduction to Part II: Surface, Scale, and Technology — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Moons and Surfaces — Reading • 5 min
- Hear More: Sarah Meister on Eugène Atget. Pendant l'éclipse. 1912 — Video • 3 min
- Hear More: Liz Deschenes on Tilt/Swing (360° field of vision, version 1), 2009 — Video • 1 min
- Surface, Scale, Technology — Dialogue • 15 min

Part III: Seeing the Unseen
- Introduction to Part III: Man on the Moon — Video • 2 min
- Photographs by NASA — Reading • 2 min
- Hear More: Sarah Meister on U.S.G.S. and NASA, Surveyor III. Surface of the Moon, Day 319, III-F. 1967 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Who Does the Moon Belong To? — Reading • 4 min

Part IV: It's Only a Paper Moon
- Introduction to Part IV: Vernacular and Fine Art Photographs of the Moon — Video • 3 min
- Moon Phases — Reading • 6 min
- Hear More: Sarah Meister on Ansel Adams. Moonrise, Hernandez, New Mexico. 1941 — Video • 3 min
- Man on the Moon and Paper Moons — Dialogue • 15 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%
- Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Part I: Introduction
- Introduction to Module 3 — Reading • 2 min
- Sarah Meister on Documents and the Documentary — Video • 3 min

Part II: Framing Reality
- Facts and Fictions — Reading • 6 min
- Fictions and Facts — Reading • 6 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Hear More: Mike Mandel on Evidence, 1977 — Video • 4 min
- Hear More: Thomas Demand on Room (Zimmer), 1996 — Video • 1 min

Part III: Words and Pictures
- Artist Spotlight: Dorothea Lange — Reading • 4 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. Migrant Mother. 1936 — Video • 2 min
- Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. On the Road to Los Angeles, California. March 1937 — Video • 1 min
- Artist Spotlight: Gordon Parks — Reading • 4 min

Part IV: Focus on New Documents, 1967
- Introduction to Part IV: Sarah Meister on New Documents — Video • 3 min
- **New Documents: Arbus, Friedlander, and Winogrand** — Reading • 4 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • 30 min
- Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
- Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min

Module 4
One and Another

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

New Documents: Arbus, Friedlander, and Winogrand

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In 1967, The Museum of Modern Art opened the exhibition *New Documents*, which featured the works of photographers Diane Arbus, Lee Friedlander, and Garry Winogrand. Calling upon the documentary mode of photography, the three artists produced descriptive records of their surroundings, however, unlike their predecessors, they employed this style to completely different ends. While the documentary photography of Dorothea Lange and Gordon Parks was meant to shed a light on social issues, the documentary photography of Winogrand, Friedlander, and Arbus was meant to make personal statements. As curator John Szarkowski wrote, "Their aim has been not to reform life, but to know it."

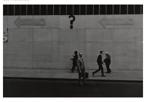
Garry Winogrand



Garry Winogrand. *Central Park Zoo, New York City*. 1967. Gelatin silver print, 8 7/8 × 13 3/8" (22.5 × 34 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. © 2020 The Estate of Garry Winogrand. Courtesy Fraenkel Gallery

A white woman in a fashionable headscarf and a Black man in a tailored jacket and tie walk through a park together, each holding an equally well-dressed monkey. When Garry Winogrand captured this moment on film, he also constructed an absurd visual metaphor for an interracial family. The image is informed by a history of scientific racism, which compared Black people to monkeys as a means of justifying white supremacy. Winogrand took this photo in 1967 during the height of the civil rights movement and the same year the Supreme Court deemed unconstitutional anti-miscegenation laws (policies criminalizing marriage across race). The layers of meaning in this image recall a famous quote by Winogrand, which states: "Photography is not about the thing photographed. It is about how that thing looks photographed."

Lee Friedlander



Lee Friedlander. *New York City*. 1962. Gelatin silver print, 5 1/4 × 8" (13.3 × 20.3 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Carl Jacobs Fund. © 2020 Lee Friedlander

In a review for the *New York Times*, Jacob Deschin highlights the ironic quality of Friedlander's work: "He has a sharp eye for juxtaposition, for a kind of one-shot photomontage, in which subject and reflection combine to make a third image. He shares with Mr. Winogrand a fine sense of humor." The wit in Friedlander's work is especially apparent in this image where a self-assured businessman stands in the street while others bustle across the sidewalk behind him. A seemingly ordinary scene, the image is quite literally punctuated by the question mark that hovers above the businessman's head.

Diane Arbus



Diane Arbus. *Puerto Rican Woman with Beauty Mark, New York City*. 1965. Gelatin silver print, printed by Neil Selkirk, 14 11/16 × 14 5/8" (37.3 × 37.2 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Purchase. © 2020 The Estate of Diane Arbus

While Winogrand and Friedlander depicted their subjects in unguarded moments, Arbus typically gave her subjects the opportunity to present themselves as they saw fit. Starting in 1962, she used medium-format cameras that were held at the waist, requiring her to look down into the viewfinder so nothing came between her face and that of her subject. Arbus typically avoided cropping her photographs and instead printed the entire negative, a choice registered by the irregular black borders surrounding her images. "For me the subject of the picture is always more important than the picture," she said. "And more complicated."

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